

1 Nephi 16-22

Jan. 29-Feb. 4

1 Nephi 16

v1 - And now it came to pass that after I, Nephi, had made an end of speaking to my brethren, behold they said unto me: **Thou hast declared unto us hard things, more than we are able to bear.**

v2 - And it came to pass that I said unto them that I knew that I had spoken hard things against the wicked, according to the truth; and the righteous have I justified, and testified that they should be lifted up at the last day; wherefore, **the guilty taketh the truth to be hard, for it cutteth them to the very center.**

Neal A. Maxwell

"God is not only there in the mildest expressions of His presence, but also in those seemingly harsh expressions. For example, when truth 'cutteth ... to the very center' (1 Ne. 16:2), this may signal that spiritual surgery is underway, painfully severing pride from the soul. (*Ensign*, November 1987, p. 31.)

"Most of us don't like to be cut to the center [see 1 Ne. 16:2], and when the gospel standards cut us it hurts. The tendency is to deal with the pain by rejecting further surgery. (*For the Power Is in Them...: Mormon Musings*, p. 49.)

v4 - And it came to pass that I, Nephi, did exhort my brethren, with all diligence, to keep the commandments of the Lord.

1 Nephi 16 – The Valley of Lemuel

v6 - Now, all these things were said and done as my father dwelt in a tent in the valley which he called Lemuel

Hugh Nibley

"Nephi...refers constantly to his father's tent as the center of his universe. To an Arab, 'My father dwelt in a tent' says everything....

"So with the announcement that his father dwelt in a tent, Nephi serves notice that he had assumed the desert way of life, as perforce he must for his journey: any easterner would appreciate the significance and importance of the statement, which to us seems almost trivial. If Nephi seems to think of his father's tent as the hub of everything, he is simply expressing the view of any normal Bedouin (Arabian tent dweller)." (*Lehi in the Desert and The World of the Jaredites*, pp. 57-8)

v7 - And it came to pass that I, Nephi, took one of the daughters of Ishmael to wife

v9 - And it came to pass that the voice of the Lord spake unto my father by night, and commanded him that on the morrow he should take his journey into the wilderness.

v10 - And it came to pass that as my father arose in the morning, and went forth to the tent door, to his great astonishment he beheld upon the ground a round ball of curious workmanship; and it was of fine brass. And within the ball were two spindles; and the one pointed the way whither we should go into the wilderness.

The Liahona

Thomas S. Monson

"If man can invent sonar to warn against disaster, and if he can invent whiskers to put on automobile fenders for the protection of white sidewall tires, doesn't it sound reasonable that the Lord would place a warning device within His children, to warn us when we are on a detour, away from His pathway? I bear you my testimony today that we have a guiding light. It is foolproof if we will but use it. It is known, as you know and as I know, as the **Holy Ghost**-the still small voice." (*BYU Speeches of the Year*, Nov. 5, 1963, p.4)

"The same Lord who provided a Liahona for Lehi provides for you and for me today a rare and valuable gift to give direction to our lives, to mark the hazards to our safety, and to chart the way, even safe passage-not to a promised land, but to our heavenly home. The gift to which I refer is known as a **patriarchal blessing**. Every worthy member of the Church is entitled to receive such a precious and priceless personal treasure." (*Live the Good Life*, p. 36 - 37.)

1 Nephi 16 – Into the wilderness

v13 - We traveled for the space of four days, nearly a south-southeast direction

Hugh Nibley

"As to the direction taken by Lehi's party the Book of Mormon is clear and specific. He took what we now know to have been the only possible way out, what with immediate danger threatening from the north, and the eastern and western lands held by opposing powers on the verge of war. Only the south desert, the one land where Israel's traders and merchants had felt at home through the centuries, remained open—even after Jerusalem fell this was so...

For a long time the party traveled south-southeast and then struck out almost due east over a particularly terrible desert and reached the sea...

Nephi is careful to keep us informed of the main bearing of every stage of the journey, and never once does he mention a westerly or a northerly trend. The party traveled for eight years in but two main directions, without retracing their steps or doubling back, and many of their marches were long forced marches."

1 Nephi 16 – Nephi's Bow

v16 - And we did follow the directions of the ball, which led us in the more fertile parts of the wilderness.

v18 - And it came to pass that as I, Nephi, went forth to slay food, behold, **I did break my bow, which was made of fine steel**; and after I did break my bow, behold, **my brethren were angry with me** because of the loss of my bow, for we did obtain no food.

v19 - And it came to pass that we did return without food to our families, and being much fatigued, because of their journeying, they did suffer much for the want of food.

v20 - ...and also my father began to murmur against the Lord his God; yea, and they were all exceedingly sorrowful,

Neal A. Maxwell

"There was murmuring, too, because Nephi broke his steel bow and also because he couldn't possibly build a ship (see 1 Nephi 16:18-20; 17:17). Those same murmurers, insensitive to their inconsistency, quickly surfeited themselves on the meat brought back by Nephi's new bow. They also sailed successfully over vast oceans to a new hemisphere in the ship that Nephi couldn't build. Strange, isn't it, how those with the longest lists of new demands also have the shortest memories of past blessings?"
(*If Thou Endure It Well*, p. 125.)

1 Nephi 16 – Whither shall I go?

v23 - And it came to pass that **I Nephi, did make out of wood a bow**, and out of a straight stick, an arrow; wherefore, I did arm myself with a bow and an arrow, with a sling and with stones.

- **And I said unto my father: Whither shall I go to obtain food?**

v24 - And it came to pass that he did inquire of the Lord, for they had humbled themselves because of my words; for I did say many things unto them in the energy of my soul.

v28 - And it came to pass that I, Nephi, beheld the pointers which were in the ball, that they did work according to the **faith and diligence and heed** which we did give unto them.

v29 - And thus we see that **by small means the Lord can bring about great things.**

By small means the Lord can bring about great things

M. Russell Ballard

"Great and marvelous events seem to motivate us, but small things often do not hold our attention. Noting that the Liahona worked by faith, Alma stated, 'Nevertheless, because those miracles were worked by small means . . . the people of Lehi were slothful, and forgot to exercise their faith and diligence and then those marvelous works ceased, and they did not progress in their journey.' (Alma 37:41.)

"Is our journey sometimes impeded when we forget the importance of small things? (See Alma 37:46.) Do we realize that small events and choices determine the direction of our lives just as small helms determine the direction of great ships? (See James 3:4; D&C 123:16.)

James 3:4 - Behold also the ships, which though they be so great, and are driven of fierce winds, yet are they turned about with a very small helm, whithersoever the governor listeth.

The 'little things'

"A series of seemingly small but incorrect choices,' **Elder M. Russell Ballard** pointed out, 'can become those little soul-destroying termites that eat away at the foundations of our testimony until, before we are aware, we may be brought near to spiritual and moral destruction.'

In a similar way, the small acts of kindness, the tiny deeds of Christian service, the silent but significant efforts to control our own thoughts and feelings-these are the simple things that build character and shape human destiny everlastingly.

The world takes notice of the public accomplishments, the spectacular victories. But who knows of the private battles of the soul, thousands of them, waged and won... to become a friend of God? Who knows of the infinite struggles, the buffetings, the adversarial onslaughts faced and overcome...?

Truly, the 'little things' form and shape the disciple of Christ." (Robert L. Millet, *An Eye Single to the Glory of God: Reflections on the Cost of Discipleship*, p.77.)

When life breaks your bow, make a new one! And inquire of the Lord for help.

Q: How could you apply Nephi's attitude to one of your present problems?

Q: Is there anything within your control that you could do to “build your own bow”?

Q: How might you include the Lord in dealing with your challenge?

1 Nephi 16 - Compounding the crisis

v30 - And it came to pass that I, Nephi, **did go forth up into the top of the mountain**, according to the directions which were given upon the ball.

v31 - And it came to pass that I did slay wild beasts, insomuch that I did obtain food for our families.

v34 - **Ishmael... was buried in the place which was called Nahom**

v35 - And it came to pass that the daughters of Ishmael did **mourn exceedingly**, because of the **loss** of their father, and because of their **afflictions** in the wilderness; and they did murmur against my father, because he had brought them out of the land of Jerusalem, saying: Our father is dead; yea, and we have **wandered much** in the wilderness, and **we have suffered much affliction, hunger, thirst, and fatigue**; and after all these sufferings **we must perish in the wilderness** with hunger.

v36 - And thus they did murmur against my father, and also against me; **and they were desirous to return again to Jerusalem.**

v37 - And Laman said unto Lemuel and also unto the sons of Ishmael: Behold, let us slay our father, and also our brother Nephi, who has taken it upon him to be our ruler and our teacher, who are his elder brethren.

Lord will not allow this mission to fail

39 And it came to pass that the Lord was with us, yea, even the voice of the Lord came and did speak many words unto them, and did chasten them exceedingly; and after they were chastened by the voice of the Lord they did turn away their anger, and did repent of their sins, insomuch that the Lord did bless us again with food, that we did not perish.

The Lord will not allow this mission to fail. He will not allow Laman and Lemuel to kill Lehi and Nephi. He intervenes with Laman and Lemuel as little as possible but enough to suit His purposes.

In this particular instance, they actually heard the voice of the Lord which did chasten them exceedingly.

Of this event, 1 Ne 17:46 says, he has spoken unto you like unto the voice of thunder, which did cause the earth to shake as if it were to divide asunder.

It took the voice of God to control these rebels.

Again, we are amazed that they see so many miracles, even hear the voice of the Lord, and yet they still will not hearken to the words of the Lord.

1 Nephi 17 - Arabian Peninsula

v1 - And we did travel and wade through much affliction in the wilderness; and our women did bear children in the wilderness.

v2 - And so great were the blessings of the Lord upon us, that while **we did live upon raw meat in the wilderness, our women...were strong**, yea, even like unto the men; and they began to bear their journeyings without murmurings.

v4 - Why did it take them 8 years to travel the Arabian Peninsula?

Alma 37:41-43 - They were slothful, and forgot to exercise their faith and diligence and then those marvelous works (ie. the Liahona) ceased, and they did not progress in their journey; therefore, they tarried in the wilderness, or did not travel a direct course, and were afflicted with hunger and thirst, because of their transgressions...for as our fathers were slothful to give heed to this compass (now these things were temporal) they did not prosper; even so it is with things which are spiritual'

1 Nephi 17 – Bountiful

v5 - And we did come to **the land which we called Bountiful**, because of its much fruit and also wild honey; and all these things were prepared of the Lord that we might not perish. And we beheld the sea...

v6 - And it came to pass that we did pitch our tents by the seashore; and notwithstanding we had suffered many afflictions and much difficulty, yea, even so much that we cannot write them all, we were exceedingly rejoiced when we came to the seashore;

v12 the Lord had not suffered that we should make much fire; I will make thy food become sweet, that ye cook it not;

v13 And I will also be your light in the wilderness

When we have difficulties, we often ask the Lord to remove our obstacles, to bring a quick end to our suffering. In the Lord's plan, instead of removing our afflictions, He often wants us to continue in our tribulations, but gives us the necessary strength to come out victorious.

1 Nephi 17 – Arise, Nephi!

v7 - And it came to pass that after I, Nephi, had been in the land of Bountiful for the space of many days, the voice of the Lord came unto me, saying: **Arise**, and get thee into the mountain. And it came to pass that I arose and went up into the mountain, **and cried unto the Lord**.

v8 - And it came to pass that the Lord spake unto me, saying: Thou shalt **construct a ship, after the manner which I shall show thee**, that I may carry thy people across these waters.

v9 - And I said: Lord, **whither shall I go that I may find ore** to molten, **that I may make tools** to construct the ship after the manner which thou hast shown unto me?

v10 - And it came to pass that the Lord told me whither I should go to find ore, that I might make tools.

v11 - And it came to pass that I, Nephi, did make a bellows wherewith to blow the fire, of the skins of beasts; and after I had made a bellows, that I might have wherewith to blow the fire, I did smite two stones together that I might make fire.

1 Nephi 17 - Our brother is a fool!

v17 - **Our brother is a fool, for he thinketh that he can build a ship;** yea, and he also thinketh that he can cross these great waters.

v18 - And thus my brethren did complain against me, and **were desirous that they might not labor,** for they did not believe that I could build a ship; neither would they believe that I was instructed of the Lord.

v19 - And now it came to pass that I, Nephi, was exceedingly sorrowful because of the hardness of their hearts; and **now when they saw that I began to be sorrowful they were glad in their hearts,** insomuch that they did rejoice over me, saying: We knew that ye could not construct a ship, for we knew that ye were lacking in judgment; wherefore, thou canst not accomplish so great a work.

v20 - And thou art like unto our father, led away by the foolish imaginations of his heart; **it would have been better that they (our women) had died before they came out of Jerusalem** than to have suffered these afflictions.

v21 - Behold, these many years we have suffered in the wilderness, **which time we might have enjoyed our possessions** and the land of our inheritance; yea, **and we might have been happy.**

1 Nephi 17 – A voice that one feels more than hears

v41 - because of the simpleness of the way, or the easiness of it, there were many who perished

v45 - he hath spoken unto you in a still small voice, but ye were past feeling, that ye could not feel his words.

Boyd K. Packer

"We do not have the words (even the scriptures do not have words) which perfectly describe the Spirit," he told new mission presidents and their wives at a seminar on 19 June 1991. "The scriptures usually use the word voice, which does not exactly fit. These delicate, refined spiritual communications are not seen with our eyes nor heard with our ears.... It is a voice that one feels more than one hears.

"Once I came to understand this, one verse in the Book of Mormon took on profound meaning and my testimony of the book became fixed. The verse had to do with Laman and Lemuel, who rebelled against Nephi. Nephi rebuked them and said: 'Ye have seen an angel, and he spake unto you; yea, ye have heard his voice from time to time; and he hath spoken unto you in a still small voice, but ye were past feeling, that ye could not feel his words' (1 Nephi 17:45)."

"I have come to know that inspiration comes more as a feeling than as a sound," Elder Packer repeated in general conference, October 1979. He then counseled: "Ponder and pray quietly and persistently.... The answer may not come as a lightning bolt. It may come as a little inspiration here and a little there, 'line upon line, precept upon precept' (D&C 98:12).

"Some answers will come from reading the scriptures, some from hearing speakers. And, occasionally, when it is important, some will come by very direct and powerful inspiration. The promptings will be clear and unmistakable."

1 Nephi 18 – Pray always

v2 - Now I, Nephi, did not work the timbers after the manner which was learned by men, neither did I build the ship after the manner of men; but I did build it after the manner which the Lord had shown unto me; wherefore, it was not after the manner of men.

v3 - And I, Nephi, did go into the mount oft, and **I did pray oft** unto the Lord; wherefore the Lord showed unto me great things.

"Nephi was a man of prayer. He instructed those of our generation to '**pray always,**' and '**not [to] perform any thing unto the Lord save in the first place ye shall pray unto the Father in the name of Christ**' (2 Nephi 32:9). It is also of interest that Nephi had a place of prayer, that being 'the mount' where he would make his ritual ascent to the divine presence. (McConkie and Millet, *Doctrinal Commentary on the Book of Mormon*, vol. 1, p. 140)

v5 - And it came to pass that the voice of the Lord came unto my father, that we should arise and go down into the ship.

1 Nephi 18

v9 - And after we had been driven forth before the wind for the space of many days, behold, my brethren and the sons of Ishmael and also their wives **began to make themselves merry**, insomuch that they began to dance, and to sing, and to speak with much rudeness, yea, even that they did forget by what power they had been brought thither; yea, **they were lifted up unto exceeding rudeness.**

v10 - And I, Nephi, began to fear exceedingly lest the Lord should be angry with us, and smite us because of our iniquity, that we should be swallowed up in the depths of the sea; wherefore, I, Nephi, **began to speak to them with much soberness**; but behold **they were angry** with me, saying: We will not that our younger brother shall be a ruler over us.

v11 - And it came to pass that Laman and Lemuel **did take me and bind me with cords**, and they did treat me with much harshness; **nevertheless, the Lord did suffer it** that he might show forth his power, unto the fulfilling of his word which he had spoken concerning the wicked.

v12 - And it came to pass that after they had bound me insomuch that I could not move, **the compass, which had been prepared of the Lord, did cease to work.**

1 Nephi 18

v13 - Wherefore, **they knew not whither they should steer the ship**, insomuch that there arose a great storm, yea, **a great and terrible tempest**, and we were **driven back upon the waters** for the space of three days; and they began to be frightened exceedingly lest they should be drowned in the sea; nevertheless they did not loose me.

v17 - Behold, **they did breathe out much threatenings against anyone that should speak for me**; and **my parents** being stricken in years, and having suffered much grief because of their children, **they were brought down, yea, even upon their sick-beds.**

v19 - And Jacob and Joseph also, being young, **having need of much nourishment, were grieved** because of the afflictions of their mother; and also **my wife with her tears and prayers**, and also **my children**, did not soften the hearts of my brethren that they would loose me.

v14 - And on the fourth day, which we had been driven back, **the tempest began to be exceedingly sore.**

v15 - And it came to pass that **we were about to be swallowed up in the depths of the sea.**

1 Nephi 18 - Praise God all the day long

v15 - Wherefore, they came unto me, and loosed the bands which were upon my wrists, and behold they had swollen exceedingly; and also mine ankles were much swollen, and great was the soreness thereof.

v16 - Nevertheless, **I did look unto my God, and I did praise him all the day long**; and I did not murmur against the Lord because of mine afflictions.

v21 - And it came to pass after they had loosed me, behold, **I took the compass, and it did work whither I desired it. And it came to pass that I prayed unto the Lord; and after I had prayed the winds did cease, and the storm did cease, and there was a great calm.**

v22 - And it came to pass that I, Nephi, did guide the ship, that we sailed again towards the promised land.

1 Nephi 18 - The Promised Land

v23 - And it came to pass that after we had sailed for the space of many days we did arrive at the promised land; and we went forth upon the land, and did pitch our tents; and we did call it the promised land.

v24 - And it came to pass that we did begin to till the earth, and we began to plant seeds; yea, we did put all our seeds into the earth, which we had brought from the land of Jerusalem. And it came to pass that **they did grow exceedingly**; wherefore, **we were blessed in abundance**.

v25 - And it came to pass that we did find upon the land of promise, as we journeyed in the wilderness, that there were beasts in the forests of every kind, both the cow and the ox, and the ass and the horse, and the goat and the wild goat, and all manner of wild animals, which were for the use of men. And we did find all manner of ore, both of gold, and of silver, and of copper.